THE PET ECONOMY

A pet's life is not what it used to be. Today, there's a venture to indulge every one of their whims

By **SONALI ACHARJEE**

Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH**

Ram and Shyam begin their day with a lap in their own private pool. Once they emerge from its heated waters, a helper stands by to dry them with Egyptian cotton towels. Their nails are rubbed with a special Ayurvedic herbal blend to prevent germs and infections, after which they go for a leisurely stroll around Delhi's Sainik Farms. Breakfast is either boiled salmon with jasmine rice or a hearty lamb shank stew, followed by a long snooze on their own balcony. Of course when the Delhi winter gets too cold for comfort, they sleep indoors curled up at the feet of Mommy under a goose-down duvet. Nap over, they have an hour-long play session with the babysitter. The day ends with a dinner of blueberry oatmeal, asparagus soup or nani's special homemade *khichdi*. Pampered brats? Not really. Ram and Shyam are two Indian dogs that Dhruv Bhasin, 33, rescued from the streets of Delhi in 2020.

Clearly, a dog's life is not what it used to be—guard the house, shower love on your human or strut your stuff at a dog show or two. In return, you could probably get a place of your own called a kennel, perhaps a collar with your own name tag, a hand-knit sweater, and a chewy bone for treat if not the family's worn-out slippers. Outings would be a walk in the park, or a trip to the vet.

That's how Shallu K., a 66-year-old Bangalorean who has owned close to 20 dogs so far, remembers it. "Baths would mean a simple bar of Dettol soap and the hosepipe in the lawn. We never put coats and t-shirts on our dogs even when we took them to the hills in the winter. They ate bread and milk, not the blueberries and the gluten-free specialty dog foods you see today."

Today, that could have PETA snapping at your heels. Pets in the modern family have all the privileges that humans do. They are